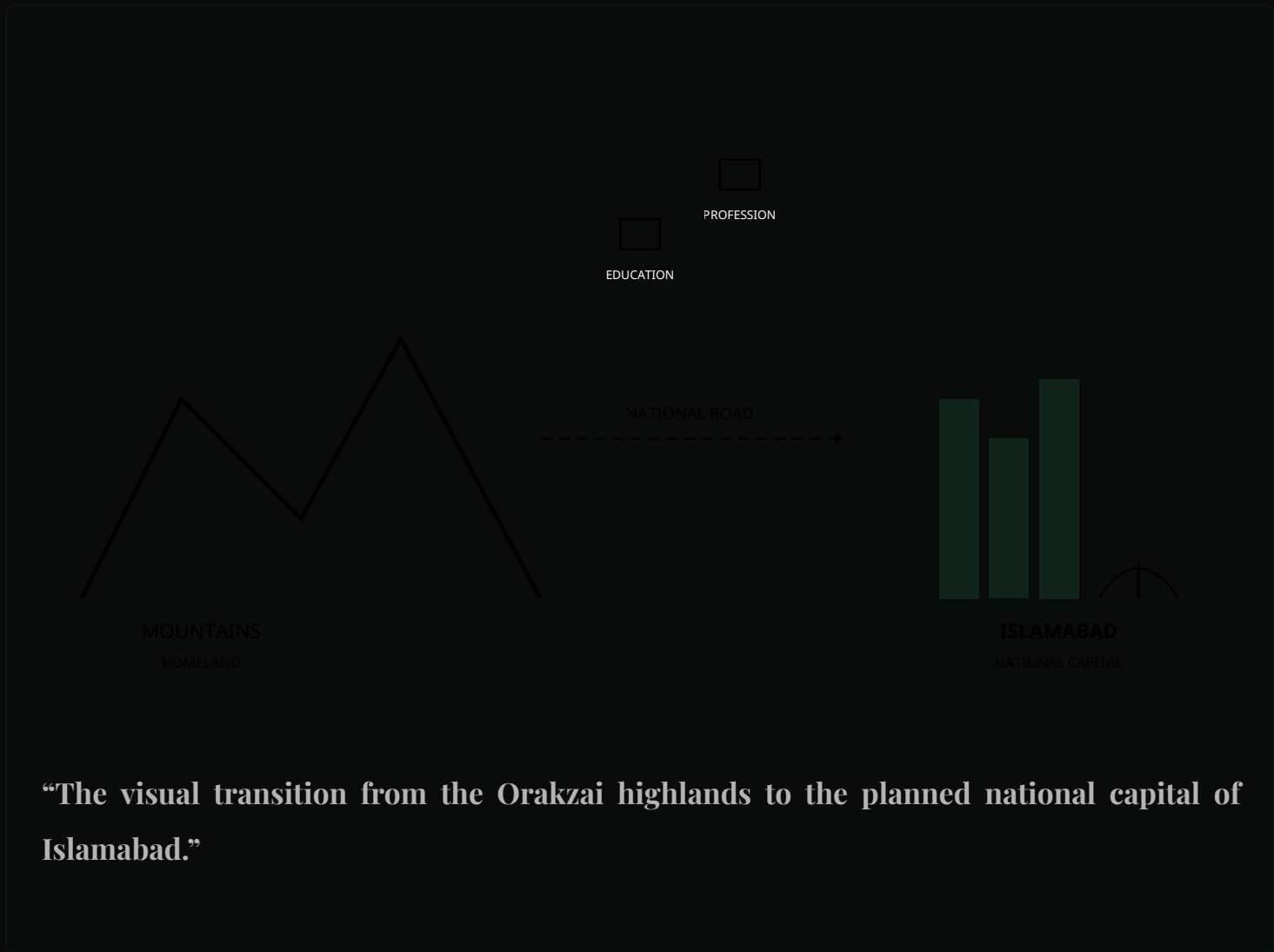


ORAKZAI IN ISLAMABAD

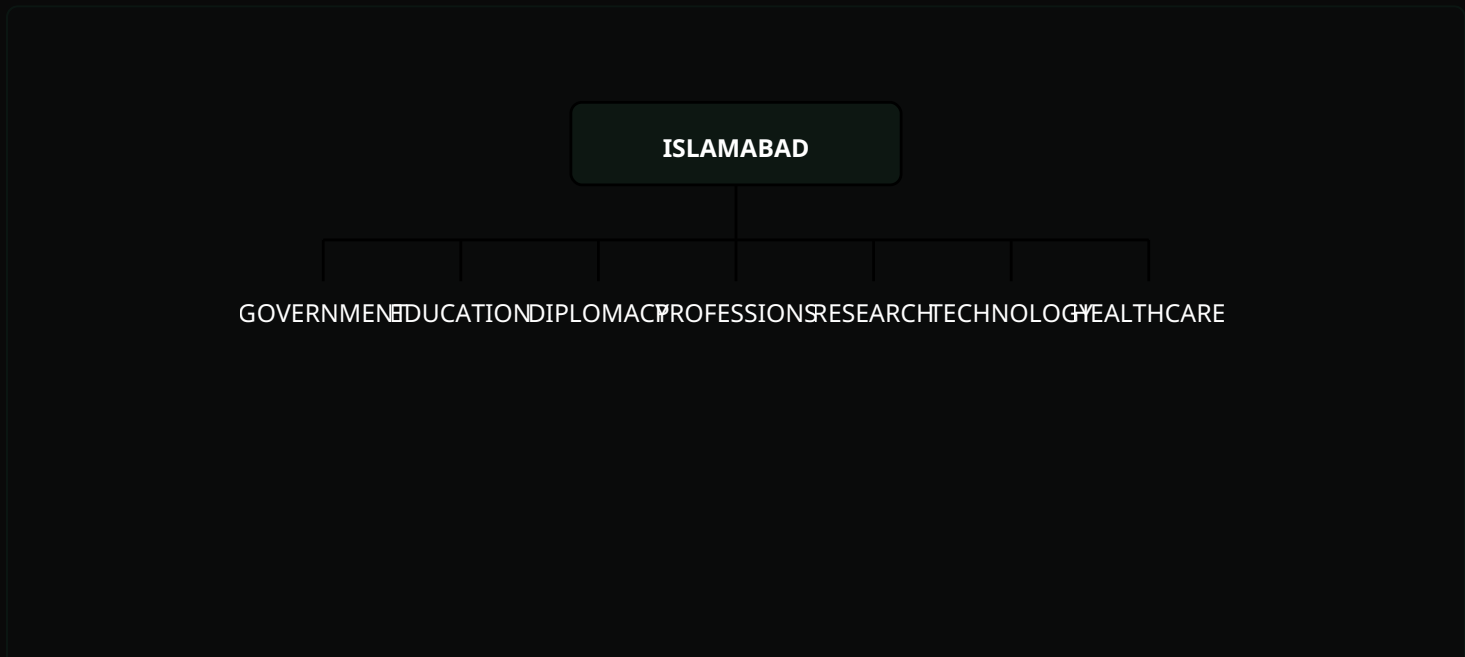
“From the mountains of Orakzai to Pakistan's national capital.”

Islamabad is different from the cities that came before it in this book. Peshawar grew from a historic regional centre. Karachi became a vast commercial metropolis. Islamabad was planned as Pakistan's national capital. Its institutions, universities, diplomatic missions, government offices and expanding professional economy attract people from across the country. For an Orakzai person, therefore, Islamabad can represent something different from the homeland. It can be a place of education. A government posting. A professional career. A business opportunity. A university campus. A hospital. A temporary residence. Or a new home. Yet living in the capital does not necessarily mean leaving the homeland behind. Family connections, language, memories, visits and traditions can continue across the distance. The story of Orakzai in Islamabad is therefore not simply a story of migration. It is a story of how identity travels into a modern national city.



ISLAMABAD AS THE NATIONAL CAPITAL

Islamabad serves as the national administrative and federal government center. Its role extends beyond governance to encompass diplomacy, research, technology, and high-tier healthcare. For the Orakzai people, the capital represents a gateway to national institutions and professional networks that connect the district to the wider state.⁴



“The multi-functional roles of Islamabad as Pakistan's national capital.”

ISLAMABAD'S URBAN HISTORY

Academic research documents the rapid transformation of Islamabad from a planned town to a sprawling metropolis. Between 1979 and 2019, the city's built-up area expanded by over 40%. This growth reflects the increasing centralization of the Pakistani state and its economy, creating a magnet for professionals and students from regions like Orakzai.^{1 2}

41.7%

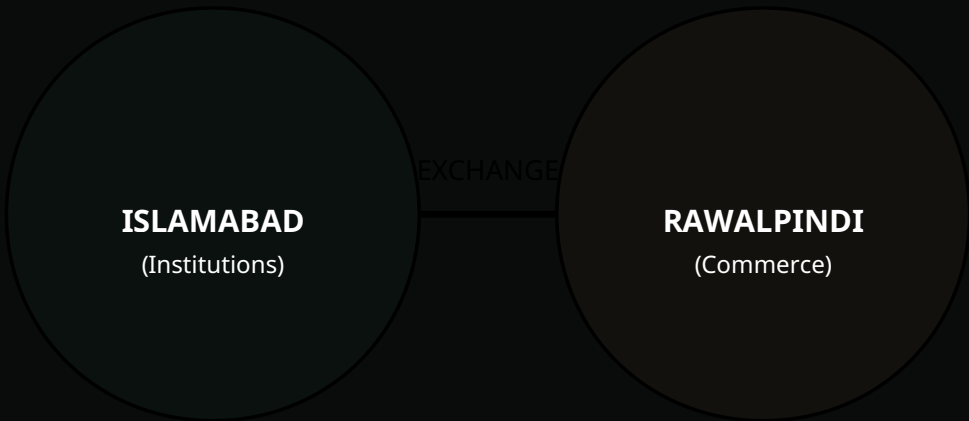
BUILT-UP EXPANSION (1979–2019)

25.7%

TOTAL BUILT-UP AREA (2021)

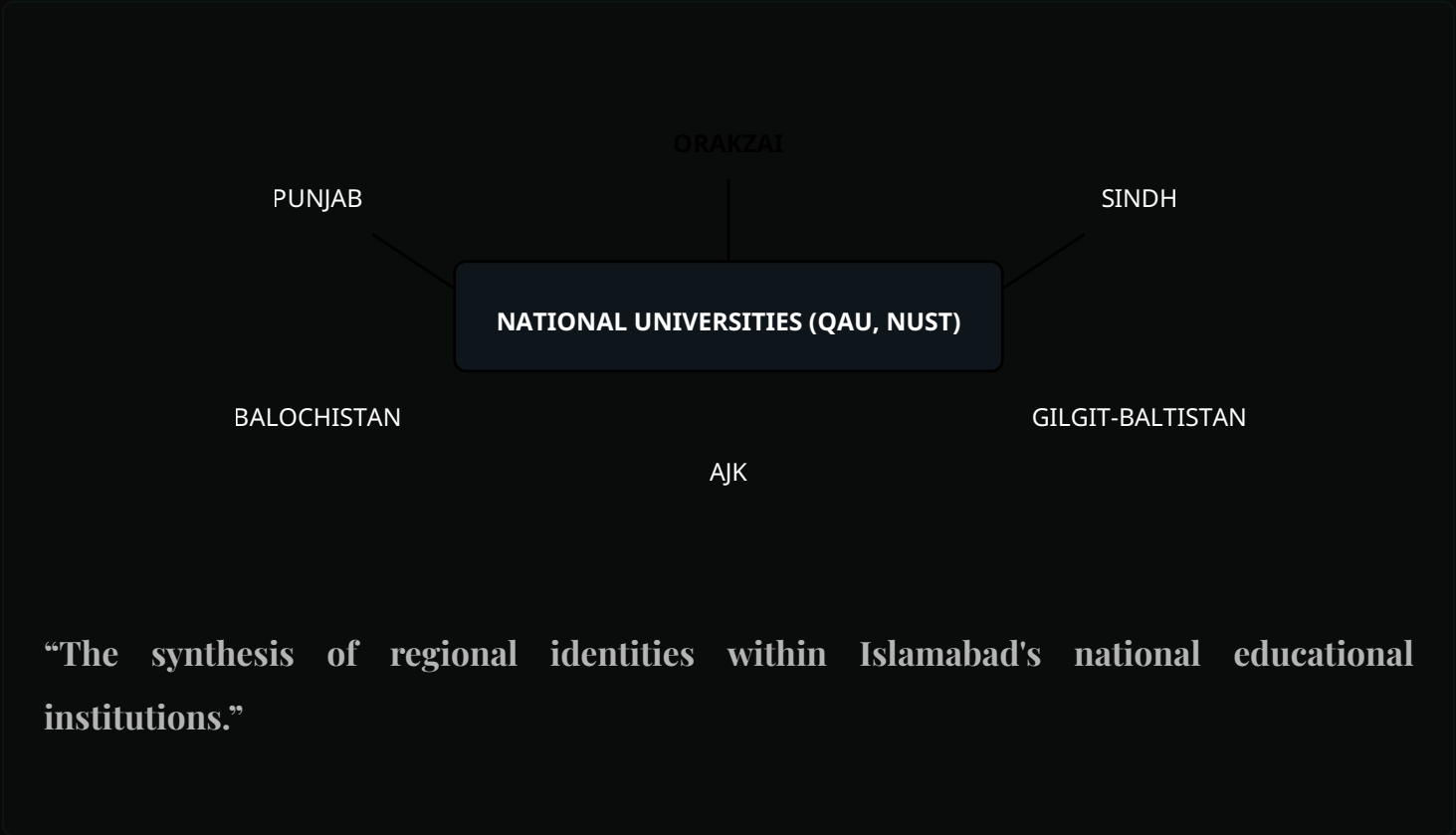
ISLAMABAD AND RAWALPINDI

The relationship between Islamabad and Rawalpindi is fundamental to the urban experience. While Islamabad hosts the national institutions, Rawalpindi often provides the commercial backbone and more affordable housing for many migrants. This metropolitan network allows Orakzai families to navigate a dual urban environment.⁴



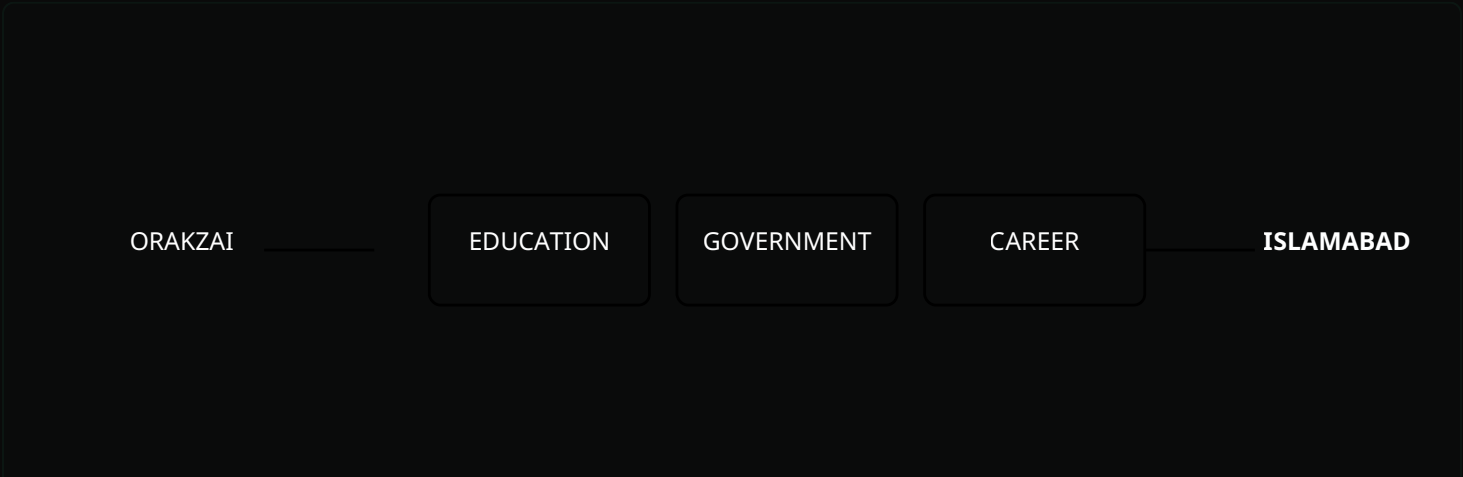
“The symbiotic relationship within the Islamabad–Rawalpindi metropolitan network.”

Universities like Quaid-i-Azam University (QAU) and NUST serve as critical sites where Orakzai students join a national educational environment. These institutions bring together individuals from all provinces, fostering a professional class that balances tribal identity with national citizenship.³



WHY ISLAMABAD?

Migration to Islamabad is often driven by the pursuit of professional careers, higher education, and access to national-level institutions. For the Orakzai community, the capital represents a space of modern opportunity where tribal roots are supplemented by the tools of the contemporary state.⁴



“The primary drivers of Orakzai migration to the national capital.”

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Islamabad is where the Orakzai story joins the national narrative of Pakistan. It is a city of broad avenues and green spaces, a place where our young people come to study the laws of the land and the science of the future. In the offices of the Secretariat or the lecture halls of QAU, I see Orakzai faces—individuals who have carried the strength of our valleys into the heart of the national capital. We are no longer a people defined only by our mountains; we are a people who contribute to the building of our nation. Islamabad has changed us, but it has also given us a platform to show the world who we are. We are Orakzai, and we are part of the future of Pakistan.

“FROM THE HIGHLANDS TO THE HEART OF THE NATION.”

ORAKZAI IN ISLAMABAD ANALYSIS